



PIRLS Reading Practice — Year 5

Providence English Private School

Set 4: Journey to the Great Barrier Reef

Informational Text · 13 Questions · 40 Minutes

Name: _____ Class: _____ Date: _____

Journey to the Great Barrier Reef

Stretching along the coast of northeastern Australia, the Great Barrier Reef is the largest living structure on Earth. It is so enormous that it can be seen from space, running for more than 2,300 kilometres — roughly the distance from London to Cairo. Yet despite its size, the reef is built by creatures so small that thousands of them could fit on your thumbnail.

These tiny creatures are called coral polyps. Each polyp is a soft-bodied animal, related to jellyfish and sea anemones, that builds a hard, cup-shaped skeleton around itself using minerals from the surrounding seawater. When thousands of polyps grow together, generation after generation, their skeletons form the rock-like structures we recognise as coral. Over thousands of years, these structures grow large enough to become entire reefs, providing a foundation for one of the richest ecosystems on the planet.

The Great Barrier Reef is home to an extraordinary variety of life. Scientists estimate it supports around 1,500 species of fish, 400 species of coral, and thousands of other creatures, including sea turtles, sharks, rays, and the enormous humpback whales that pass through on their annual migration. Many of these species depend entirely on the reef for food and shelter, making it one of the most important habitats in the ocean.

Coral itself gets much of its vivid colour from tiny algae that live inside its tissue, in a relationship that benefits both partners. The algae use sunlight to produce food through photosynthesis, sharing some of this food with the coral polyp. In return, the coral provides the algae with a safe place to live and access to sunlight near the water's surface. This partnership is so important that without it, most coral could not survive.

Unfortunately, this delicate partnership is also the reef's greatest vulnerability. When ocean temperatures rise even slightly above normal, corals become stressed and expel the colourful algae living inside them. Without the algae, the coral turns pale white, a process known as coral bleaching. Bleached coral isn't necessarily dead, but it is significantly weakened, and if temperatures stay high for too long, the coral will eventually starve.

In recent decades, rising ocean temperatures linked to climate change have caused several mass bleaching events across the Great Barrier Reef, some affecting more than half of the entire reef system at once. Scientists and conservationists are working to understand which coral species are more resistant to heat, in the hope of helping the reef recover and adapt.

Protecting the reef isn't only important for the animals that live there. Millions of people around the world visit the reef each year, supporting local businesses and economies. Fishing industries also depend on healthy reef ecosystems to sustain fish populations. For these reasons, many scientists consider protecting the Great Barrier Reef to be one of the most urgent environmental challenges of our time.

Despite the threats it faces, the reef remains a place of astonishing beauty and biological richness — a reminder of how the smallest creatures, working together over immense stretches of time, can build something visible even from space.

Questions

1. MULTIPLE CHOICE · RETRIEVE

How long is the Great Barrier Reef, according to the passage?

- ☐ A About 230 kilometres
- ☐ B About 2,300 kilometres
- ☐ C About 23,000 kilometres
- ☐ D About 1,500 kilometres

2. MULTIPLE CHOICE · RETRIEVE

What are coral polyps?

- ☐ A A type of fish
- ☐ B Small, soft-bodied animals that build hard skeletons
- ☐ C A kind of seaweed
- ☐ D Rocks found on the ocean floor

3. WRITTEN RESPONSE · INTERPRET & INTEGRATE

Explain, in your own words, how individual coral polyps eventually form an entire reef.

4. MULTIPLE CHOICE · RETRIEVE

What gives coral much of its bright colour?

- ☐ A Sunlight reflecting off the water
- ☐ B Tiny algae living inside its tissue
- ☐ C Minerals from the seawater
- ☐ D The fish that swim around it

5. WRITTEN RESPONSE · INTERPRET & INTEGRATE

Describe the relationship between coral and the algae that live inside it. Why is this relationship described as benefiting both partners?

6. MULTIPLE CHOICE · RETRIEVE

What happens to coral during 'coral bleaching'?

- ☐ A It grows extra colourful algae
- ☐ B It turns pale white after expelling its algae due to heat stress
- ☐ C It multiplies rapidly
- ☐ D It changes into a different species

7. MULTIPLE CHOICE · RETRIEVE

Is bleached coral always dead? What does the passage say?

- ☐ A Yes, bleaching always kills coral instantly
- ☐ B No, but it is weakened and can die if high temperatures continue
- ☐ C No, bleaching has no effect on coral health
- ☐ D The passage does not mention this

8. WRITTEN RESPONSE · INFER

Why do scientists consider rising ocean temperatures to be such a serious threat to the reef?

9. MULTIPLE CHOICE · RETRIEVE

According to the passage, why is the reef important to people, not just marine animals?

- A It is the only source of fresh water in Australia
- B It supports tourism, local businesses, and fishing industries
- C It prevents all storms from reaching Australia
- D It provides all of Australia's electricity

10. MULTIPLE CHOICE · RETRIEVE

Which sentence from the passage best supports the idea that the reef is extremely large?

- A Coral itself gets much of its vivid colour from tiny algae.
- B It is so enormous that it can be seen from space.
- C Bleached coral isn't necessarily dead.
- D Scientists and conservationists are working to understand which coral species are more resistant to heat.

11. WRITTEN RESPONSE · EVALUATE

The author ends the passage by calling the reef 'a reminder of how the smallest creatures... can build something visible even from space.' What point is the author making with this comparison?

12. MULTIPLE CHOICE · EVALUATE

What is the overall purpose of this passage?

- A To tell an adventure story about explorers
- B To inform readers about the reef and the threats it faces
- C To persuade readers to stop eating fish
- D To compare different oceans around the world

13. WRITTEN RESPONSE · EVALUATE

Based on the information in the passage, do you think enough is being done to protect the Great Barrier Reef? Explain your reasoning using evidence from the text.

Answer Key & Model Answers

1. B — About 2,300 kilometres

The passage states it runs for more than 2,300 kilometres.

2. B — Small, soft-bodied animals that build hard skeletons

The passage describes polyps as soft-bodied animals related to jellyfish that build hard skeletons.

3. Written response

Model answer: Thousands of tiny coral polyps build hard skeletons around themselves, and as generation after generation grows on top of the last over thousands of years, these skeletons build up into the large rock-like structures that form a reef.

Marking guidance: Full credit: explains the accumulation over many polyps and time. Partial credit: mentions polyps building skeletons without explaining the accumulation/scale over time.

4. B — Tiny algae living inside its tissue

The passage explains that algae living inside coral tissue give it much of its colour.

5. Written response

Model answer: The algae use sunlight to make food through photosynthesis and share some of it with the coral, while the coral gives the algae a safe, sunlit place to live — so each partner gains something it needs, which is why it benefits both.

Marking guidance: Full credit: explains what each partner gives and receives. Partial credit: states it's a helpful relationship without explaining what each side provides.

6. B — It turns pale white after expelling its algae due to heat stress

The passage explains that heat-stressed coral expels its algae, causing it to turn white.

7. B — No, but it is weakened and can die if high temperatures continue

The passage states bleached coral isn't necessarily dead, but is weakened and can eventually starve if conditions don't improve.

8. Written response

Model answer: Rising temperatures stress coral and cause it to expel the algae it depends on for food, and if the heat continues, the coral can starve and die — and this has already caused mass bleaching events affecting more than half the reef at times.

Marking guidance: Full credit: connects temperature rise to the bleaching process and its scale/severity. Partial credit: says 'it kills coral' without explaining the bleaching mechanism.

9. B — It supports tourism, local businesses, and fishing industries

The passage explains the reef supports tourism, local economies, and fishing industries.

10. B — It is so enormous that it can be seen from space.

This sentence directly emphasises the reef's massive scale, visible even from space.

11. Written response

Model answer: The author is highlighting the contrast between the tiny size of individual coral polyps and the astonishing scale of what they create together over time, making the point that small, patient, collective effort can produce something enormous and remarkable.

Marking guidance: Full credit: identifies the small-vs-large contrast and the idea of collective effort over time. Partial credit: restates the sentence without explaining the intended point.

12. B — To inform readers about the reef and the threats it faces

The passage is structured to inform, combining facts about the reef's biology, ecosystem, and the threats facing it.

13. Written response

Model answer: Answers will vary. A strong response might note that scientists are actively researching heat-resistant coral, which is encouraging, but that mass bleaching events affecting more than half the reef suggest the problem remains serious and unresolved.

Marking guidance: Full credit: gives a reasoned opinion supported by specific evidence from the passage (e.g., ongoing research vs. scale of bleaching events). Partial credit: gives an opinion with vague or no supporting evidence.